

WHERE THE REVENUE ACTUALLY IS

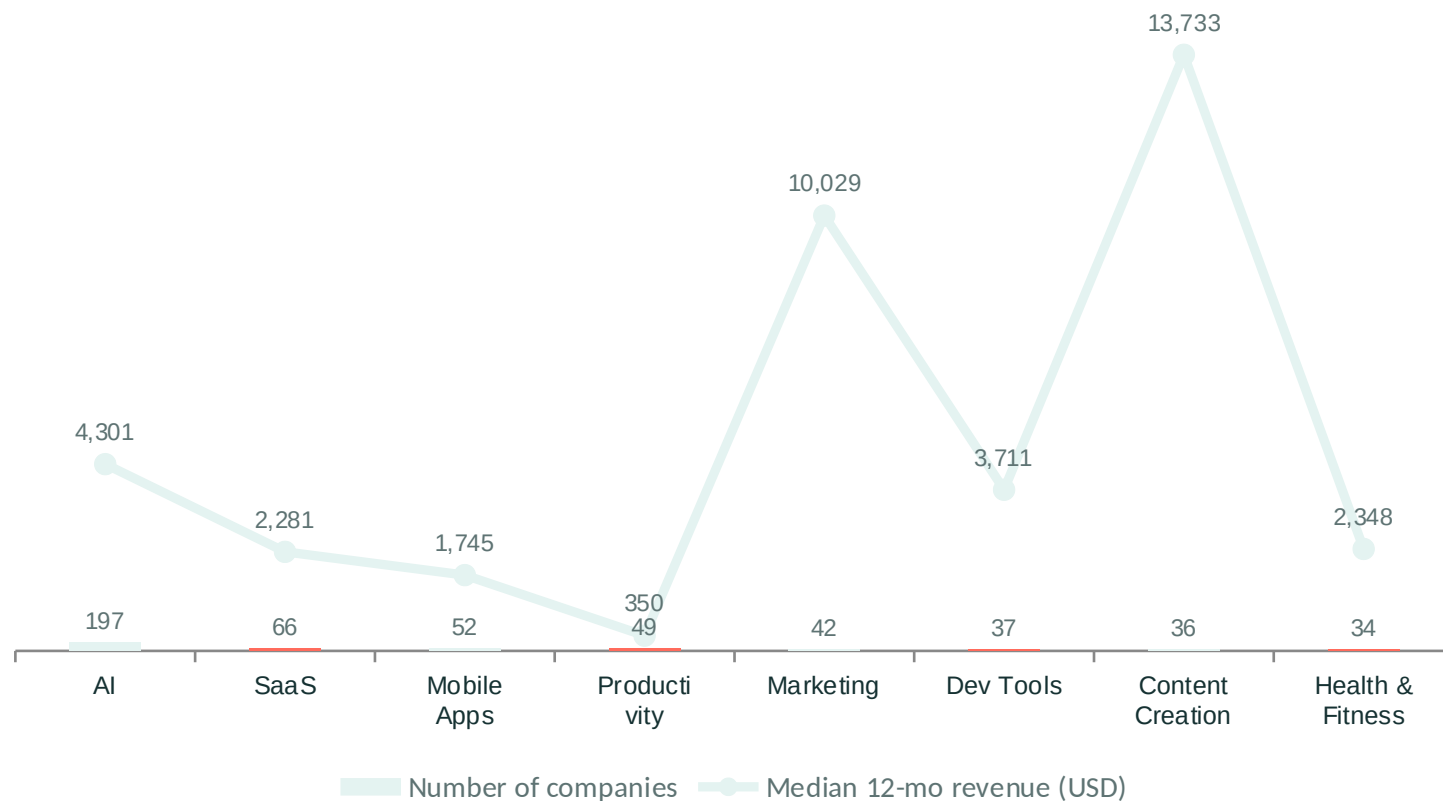
Category Insights from 1,000 Startup Listings

Which categories are crowded, which pay the most per customer, and where a newcomer actually has room to win.

Source: TrustMRR marketplace data

The AI Gold Rush Problem

The most crowded category is one of the weakest earners



● Coral line = median 12-month revenue, in US dollars. Bars = how many companies are in each category.

197

AI companies — 20% of the whole dataset, the single biggest category.

...yet it ranks 6th of 8 on typical revenue.

Education and **Content Creation** — far smaller — earn 3x more per company.

Crowded / lucrative. Popularity is not a revenue signal.

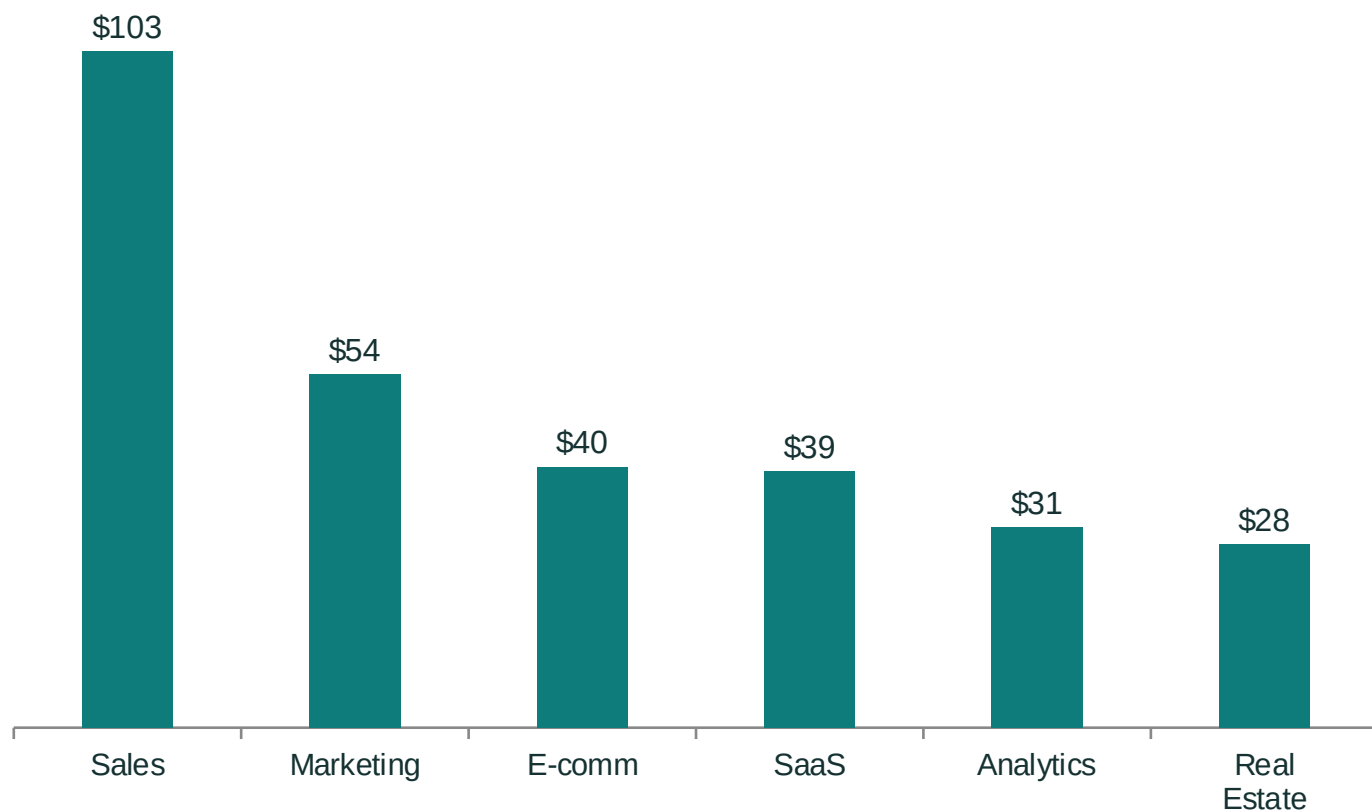
Categories Worth Exploring

Strong revenue, thinner competition than AI — compared across five metrics

Education	Content Creation	Marketing	Sales
\$14.3K median 12-mo rev	\$13.7K median 12-mo rev	\$10.0K median 12-mo rev	\$8.2K median 12-mo rev
Median MRR	Median MRR	Median MRR	Median MRR
Rev / customer	Rev / customer	Rev / customer	Rev / customer
Audience	Audience	Audience	Audience
% growing	% growing	% growing	% growing
30 listings	36 listings	42 listings	13 listings
Look up: Codédex, DataExpert, Kibu	Look up: StoryShort, Marky, Draft AI	Look up: Stack Influence, Indexsy, LocalRank	Look up: Lancer, Bookedin, DM Champ

Quickest to Revenue

Revenue earned per customer — how much each paying user is worth



Highest-value customers: Sales

\$103 per customer — the highest of any category — and it needs almost no SEO/domain authority to compete (median Domain Rating just 3).

⚠️ Caveat: Sales is a tiny sample (13 companies) and its median revenue is slipping (-11.8% in 30 days). High value per customer, but verify before betting on it.

Marketing is the safer pick: \$54/customer, 42 companies, 50% still growing.

Category Playbooks

How to set up each category — payment tool, buyer, and what it means for you

Category	Payment tool	Buyer	What it means
Education	Stripe (73%)	89% B2C	Course & learning apps sold to consumers
Content Creation	Stripe (72%)	61% B2C	Creator tools — highest rev/customer of the four
Marketing	Stripe (71%)	80% B2B	Sold to businesses; strongest growth rate (50%)
Sales	Stripe (100%)	92% B2B	All-Stripe, pure B2B, premium price per seat
AI (reference)	Stripe (76%)	Split 47/40	No dominant buyer type — crowded, unfocused
Mobile Apps (ref.)	RevenueCat (79%)	98% B2C	In-app subscriptions; different payment stack

 = a "worth exploring" category from slide 3

Which Signals Actually Matter

If you want to judge whether a company is really doing well, look at these — not those

✓ TRUST THESE

✓ Monthly recurring revenue (MRR)

The strongest indicator of real size — moves almost perfectly with total revenue.

✓ Number of paying subscribers

Nearly as reliable. Real customers paying real money.

✓ Domain rating (SEO strength)

A decent secondary signal — bigger companies tend to have stronger web presence.

✗ BE SKEPTICAL OF

✗ A big 30-day growth %

Barely relates to how large a company actually is. A jump from \$10 → \$80 is "+700%" and means almost nothing.

✗ Social media following

Weak link to revenue. Lots of X followers ≠ a real business.

Bottom line: a flashy growth headline tells you nothing about real size. Follow the recurring revenue.

If You're Picking a Category

01

Don't chase the crowd.

AI has the most companies and near-bottom typical revenue. Popular ≠ profitable.

02

Explore Education, Content Creation, Marketing.

Higher typical revenue than AI, with far fewer competitors fighting for the same customers.

03

Marketing may be the best all-rounder.

\$54 per customer, 42 companies to learn from, and half of them are still growing.

04

Copy the category's proven setup.

Match the norm — Stripe + B2B for Marketing/Sales, Stripe + B2C for Education.

05

Judge companies by recurring revenue, not hype.

MRR and subscriber count show real size. A big growth % or follower count does not.